

# Nathan H O'Brien

Staff Software Engineer • Design Engineer • AI-Native / Agentic Systems

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Staff Software Engineer and design engineer specializing in the seam between design and engineering and AI-native agentic systems. A design-trained and engineering-fluent innovator who excels at translating imaginative concepts into production-ready software. Thrives in fast-paced, fluid environments, driving projects from idea to implementation with a focus on pioneering agentic frameworks. Delivers high-impact, AI-driven solutions that solve complex business challenges and accelerate development.

## // EXPERIENCE

## BuzzFeed

11 years (Mar 2015 to Jul 2026)

### Staff Software Engineer

Dec 2023 to Jul 2026 · Remote

Owner and expert of the frontend domain for the social-publishing platform. Provided thought leadership and hands-on implementation of AI-native and agentic patterns directly to the VP of Technology, contributed to AI working groups with tech leadership, and shared vision in the weekly cross-team AI dev meeting to help move AI from direction to practice across the organization:

- ▶ **Spearheaded an AI agent to take over support-ticket triage**, greatly reducing the 20 hours of weekly team time it consumed. It reached a team-wide, month-long beta running the **full loop in production** (classify → investigate → draft the fix and reply) with human sign-off on every action: **84% handling accuracy** on tickets it had never seen, trained on two years of resolved history and improving with every correction. Coordinated with other internal support-channel managers to plan its implementation throughout the company.
- ▶ **Pioneered an agentic framework migration** of a decade-old Python app to Next.js, completed in **8% of the estimated engineering time** and packaged into a **reusable blueprint to apply across twelve similar systems**.
- ▶ **Architected and shipped a dynamic image-template platform** powering automated social posts and personalized share artifacts. The redesigned share experience won its A/B test at **+176% desktop and +82% mobile share engagement**. I then made it a **turnkey, self-service path** any team could adopt.
- ▶ **Built the Callout admin platform in Next.js from scratch as lead author**. The application is an operator tool for on-site promotions with live preview (in-admin and on-site), undo/redo, autosave, themes, media uploads, and audience & device targeting.

### Senior Software Engineer

Mar 2015 to Dec 2023 · Minneapolis, MN

Owned the frontend of the social team's publishing platform for 8+ years as its domain expert, with 100+ connected channels, 40+ users, and hundreds of posts daily across six platforms:

- ▶ Built the React application which included a guided composer, mixed-media carousel composer, and self-service account-management tools.
- ▶ Set patterns beyond the product: a publishing SDK and Chrome extension, and the cross-brand rollout of a custom-built link-in-bio service.
- ▶ Helped integrate ML-based content recommendations in 2018, years before the current AI wave.
- ▶ Mentored and onboarded engineers, frequently took on design/UX ownership, and wrote test plans and managed the QA process for delivery.
- ▶ Recognized in peer reviews for unmatched visibility into the org's internal tooling; received five internal kudos awards spanning delivery, incident response, and user support.

*Performance ratings across BuzzFeed: Exceeds on Innovation and Quality (2024 and 2025 review cycles).*

### Earlier

- ▶ **N8+US, Inc · Founder / Technical Consultant** · 2010 to 2015 · Provided technical leadership, architecture, and delivery direct to national brands and agencies: scoping, estimates, and interactive application builds. For Best Buy's Emerging Platforms lab, built ML sentiment analysis over customer tweets, trained against a Google dataset, to show how customers actually experienced Twelpforce, the company's pioneering Twitter customer-service program (2010). Other clients included Oracle, Capital One, BuzzFeed, MNSure, Agosto (Google Global Partner of the Year for Cloud, 2013), and Intelligent Nutrients.
- ▶ **Schematic · Director of Technology (Minneapolis)** · 2008 to 2010 · Served as solutions architect and technical director for the Minneapolis office serving Target. Schematic was then among the premier UX and interactive-engineering firms in the US. Lead role in delivery of the **Target.com navigation redesign** and holiday projects; coordinated delivery across the New York, Los Angeles, and Costa Rica offices; charged with local talent acquisition and recruiting.

- **OLSON • Technical Creative Director / Interactive Development Supervisor (Minneapolis)** • 2004 to 2008 • Led interactive and technical delivery on dozens of accounts including Target, which grew from a small, project-based engagement into one of the agency's lead accounts (200%+ year-over-year growth, at high profitability and client satisfaction). Recruited and grew the interactive team from four to about 36 (12 full-time plus about 24 contract) delivering across 100+ clients.
- **Fallon Worldwide, Martin/Williams, and earlier agency work** • 1995 to 2004 • Freelance and staff web development: BMW.com and BMWFilms.com microsites, the Bahamas.com launch, Timberland, Microsoft, and Scotts; founding member of Martin/Williams Interactive (Target, US Bank, Walker Art Center). Started in web development in 1995.

*Early recognition: AIGA Silver and D&AD (British Design and Art Direction) Merit awards, a Microsoft case-study feature, and work featured in The Web Design WOW! Book.*

## // SKILLS

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**AI / Agentic:** LLM orchestration and multi-agent workflows • MCP servers • agentic migration pipelines • production LLM API integration • prompt and agent design • LangChain • Chainlit • Claude and OpenAI APIs • Claude Code, Copilot, and ChatGPT via VS Code

**Frontend:** React • Next.js • TypeScript • JavaScript • SSR • design systems and design tokens • styled-components • Storybook • automated testing (Playwright) • Chrome extension and Figma plugin development

**Backend / Infra:** Node.js • Python • FastAPI • Temporal (durable workflow orchestration) • PostgreSQL • Redis • Firestore • S3/CDN • Docker • GitHub Actions CI • OAuth (Okta, Clerk) • Stripe • Datadog • self-hosted PaaS (Coolify)

**Leadership:** Team building & recruiting • managing & mentoring direct reports • performance reviews • planning & resource management • technical direction & architecture • client pitches & new business • conference speaking

## // EDUCATION

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Minneapolis College of Art and Design • Interactive Design